



THE BANDS OF ASHLEY HIGH SCHOOL

Wilmington, North Carolina · ashleybands.com

RECOGNIZED STATEWIDE PROGRAM OF DISTINCTION

Inaugural class · 2025-2026
North Carolina Bandmasters Association

STORY PITCH | SEPTEMBER 2026

FROM WILMINGTON TO *Carnegie Hall*.

About 100 Eugene Ashley High School musicians will perform at Carnegie Hall's Perelman Stage on March 25, 2027. Both ensembles, the Concert Band and the Wind Ensemble, submitted recordings and were selected through the festival's application process. Six years ago this program was down to about 52 students, rehearsing outside in masks. Now both concert bands are going to New York. Separately, the program was named to the inaugural class of the NCBA Program of Distinction, a statewide recognition from the North Carolina Bandmasters Association.

WHY THIS STORY

A \$250,000 community fundraising campaign is underway so that no student has to miss this because of money. The campaign is active now, with the March 2027 performance date creating a clear, time-bound story. This is a Wilmington story about what this community's public schools produce, and whether the community shows up for them.

STORY ANGLES

- The comeback: from about 52 students rehearsing outside in masks to both concert bands at Carnegie Hall
- About 100 students, one stage: the community fundraising race to get them there
- The seven-year rebuild Mr. Parker predicted during COVID, and what sustained excellence looks like
- NCBA Program of Distinction: North Carolina's new statewide recognition for band programs
- Student voices: what Carnegie Hall means to a 16-year-old from Wilmington
- The campaign: local donors and businesses helping get them there

ASSETS AVAILABLE UPON REQUEST

- + Carnegie Hall festival acceptance documentation (both ensembles)
- + Student and parent interviews, coordinated through Rob Parker
- + Full press release and business sponsorship brief
- + NCBA Program of Distinction certification
- + High-resolution photography

THE ASK

We'd welcome 15 minutes with your news team or assignment desk to talk about how this story can reach the Wilmington community while the campaign is live. Contact Rob Parker below. Campaign page: ashleybands.com/support-carnegie

KEY CONTACTS

Robert A. Parker

Director of Bands, Ashley High School
South MPA Chair, NCBA Eastern
robert.parker@nhcs.net
(910) 409-4788

Hannah Hales

Booster President
hannah.hales@gmail.com